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How to Do Constructive Theology

Key takeaways from this chapter:

- Theology is something you do; it involves seeing the world with wisdom and discernment.
- The theological task involves at least five resources (Bible, church, tradition, experience, culture).
- Doing theology is a dynamic process and not a set procedure.
- Along with numerous other cultural forms, psychology serves as a critical resource for doing theology.

As a kid, I (Kutter) had terrible eyesight. I just didn't always know it. In fact, I distinctly remember the moment I realized how bad my vision really was. My parents were driving me home from the optometrist's office, and I was wearing my first set of prescription lenses. Dusk was falling, so I found myself looking out the car window at the moon. Awestruck by what I could now see, I continued to take my glasses off and put them on again. The difference was both glaring and astonishing. I had always known the moon existed because I wasn't completely blind, which basically meant I could identify the general location of that fuzzy glowing orb in the night sky. But never had I known how glorious the moon could be. The complexity of its cratered surface, the clarity of its circumference, the brilliance of the halos of light emanating from its center—revelations each. I was nothing short of transfixed.

Prior to that evening I had simply assumed everyone else saw the world in the same way that I did, which is to say, as blurry and nondescript. After all, the moon was simply too far away for anyone to see it with any sort of clarity. It wasn't until I was handed a set of corrective lenses that I realized just how much I had been missing and just how much more there was to see and understand. Before then, I was seeing only in the most technical sense. With my new lenses, however, I was able to make out far more detail, more depth, and more texture. Even though nothing had changed about my surroundings, everything had changed. It was as if a whole new world had opened up before me—one that I had inhabited my entire life but had never truly known, much less understood.

Of course, my story is by no means exceptional. Countless others suffer from some degree or kind of vision impairment, both literal and metaphorical. The apostle Paul said as much when he wrote to the church at Corinth that we all "see through a glass, darkly" (1 Cor. 13:12 KJV). According to Paul, we see (Greek: *blepomen*) through a reflective surface (*di esoptrou*) in an enigma (*en ainigmati*). In other words, life is incredibly complex and few things are clear. Nothing is straightforward or simple. It's almost as if, from the apostle's perspective, the whole of human life is one long attempt to make sense of a series of ancient, cryptic riddles presented in reverse image on a mirror made of hammered sheet metal. Or, to put a more modern spin on it, we're all like nearsighted kids trying to see and describe to one another the various intricacies of a glowing rock 238,900 miles away. Needless to say, that's no small task.

Centuries after Paul, the philosopher Hans-Georg Gadamer would suggest something similar. All humans, said Gadamer, interpret, understand, and, ultimately, come to know the world and their place in it from a "historically situated consciousness" (i.e., a particular sociohistorical location), which establishes the horizon beyond which they cannot see.[1] Following both Paul's and Gadamer's line of thinking, some emphasize the negative implications of this all-too-human reality, focusing on the ways that our vision is inherently limited, obscured, or otherwise clouded by the "darkness" of the

"glass" through which we see. Indeed, our vision is often far more impaired than we realize. In the absence of corrective lenses, we remain blind to the true depth of our blindness.

Thus, for both Paul and Gadamer, there's no denying that we see through a glass, *darkly*. However, there is also no denying that we can still *see* through that glass, even if darkly. This somewhat more positive assessment of the human condition should not be mistaken for a naive optimism that would ignore or deny the very real consequences of sin. Rather, it reflects an understanding of the created order as fundamentally constituted by God's trinitarian relationality, a topic we will take up in greater detail in the following chapter. For now it is enough to say that, regardless of whether one emphasizes clarity or obscurity, the inescapable truth is that to be human is simply to envision the world through a particular set of lenses that are not merely "coloring" our view of the world but also making it possible. The opaque mirrors that provide us with an indirect awareness of reality are the very things that create the necessary conditions for any human knowledge at all. From this perspective, the problem is not so much that everything we know about reality is always already filtered in some form or fashion. That's just part of what it means to be a human being. Rather, the problem is that we so often fail to recognize that our vision is filtered through any kind of lens at all.

We humans are masters at convincing ourselves that our picture of the world corresponds directly to the way things really are—as if my localized perspective somehow provides me with a total or all-encompassing view of reality that holds true for everyone, everywhere, at all times. In other words, if the moon is blurry to me, then it must be blurry for everyone because, as we all know, moons are just blurry. On this point, students of psychology share something in common with their theological counterparts, for both traditions of inquiry are concerned, on the one hand, with exposing the various ways in which we are blind to our own blindness (on both conscious and unconscious levels) and, on the other hand, with developing a deeper, more penetrating insight into the human condition. In this way, both psychology and theology seek to develop

constructive visions of life that will ultimately lead to human flourishing, but they also recognize that, in order to do so, we have to be honest about the ways in which our vision is at best, limited, and at worst, obscured.

To say that our vision is obscured is not to make a moral judgment. It is rather to say that, because we are all located somewhere, our vision is simply limited. No one has a view from nowhere. Again, that's just what it means to be human. At other times though, as the psychoanalytic tradition reminds us, we are willfully self-blinded. Making matters worse, we are also blinded by others on both interpersonal and societal levels. Still, regardless of the origins of our vision impairment, we have no chance of seeing clearly if we don't first acknowledge that each of us, in some form or fashion, needs our vision enhanced, expanded, and refined.

To move toward this kind of clarity of vision, students of psychology and theology must find a way to come to terms not only with *what* we see when we look upon the world but also with *how* we see. That is, we need a process that will enable us to see more clearly—a rigorous and reliable method that will be capable of expanding our field of view by drawing on a broader and more diverse set of resources and, at the very same time, refining our vision by allowing us to name and critically engage the various assumptions that (for good and for ill) inform and constrain our pictures of reality. Of course, a constructive theological method of this kind would be helpful for any person of faith hoping to see the world with a greater degree of clarity. However, just as a reminder, our primary concern in this book is not with Christians in general but with students of psychology in particular. Our chief aim is to equip them with a more robust set of tools and resources that will enable them to develop a growing capacity for engaging in and reflecting on psychological topics, practices, and questions in ways that are theologically informed (not to mention theologically interesting!).

To make this all a bit more concrete, consider the phoropter for a moment (see fig. 1.1). Anyone who relies on vision correction knows what a phoropter is, even if they have never heard the term. A phoropter is that medieval looking contraption an optometrist uses

during eye exams. The goal of an eye exam is obvious: clarity of vision. However, the method the optometrist uses to determine the correct prescription for a person's contacts or eyeglasses is somewhat heuristic. She cycles through a series of lenses, trying out various combinations, asking the patient to decide which lens allows them to see more clearly: "Lens number one, or lens number two? Number three, or number four?" It is a dynamic, iterative, discovery-oriented method based on a good deal of trial and error. More importantly, though, the goal of the process is not to find the one right lens that will deliver 20/20 vision, but rather to identify the unique combination of lenses that will provide the clearest picture of the object in view. And this kind of clarity emerges not by peering through a solitary lens but through a convergence of multiple lenses.

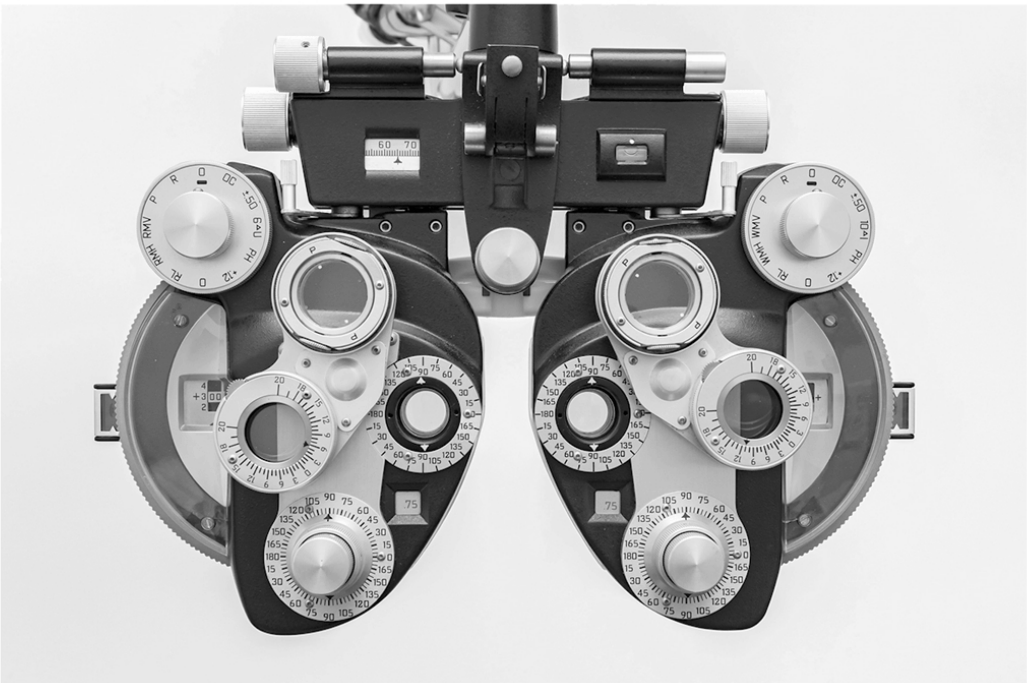

Figure 1.1. The phoropter [Rohane Hamilton / shutterstock.com]

Focusing Our Vision

The phoropter serves as a helpful metaphor for thinking about theological method in general and its relationship to psychology more specifically, in large part because it dispels some of our

misconceptions about what a method is and whether or not theology could ever be methodological.[2] You might think of theological method as somewhat analogous to what you would find in the methods section of an article published in a psychology journal, but with some very important qualifications. In the first place, as Bernard Lonergan rightly points out, "Method is not a set of rules to be followed meticulously by a dolt. It is a framework for collaborative creativity."[3] Rather than establishing a series of rigid steps designed to (re)produce a predetermined outcome, a theological method is a dynamic, creative, collaborative mode of reflection that seeks to generate insight (i.e., clarity of vision) by attending to a number of sources (i.e., lenses)—namely, the biblical text, a local worshiping community (often connected to a denomination), the historical theological tradition, one's personal experience, and the broader cultural context.

We will say more below regarding each of these normative sources, but for now it is enough to say that, as with a phoropter, the most helpful way to proceed is not to find a single, all-purpose lens that can deliver 20/20 vision, but instead to rotate through various combinations of lenses, paying special attention to points of convergence and divergence. Unfolding as it does in real time and in response to concrete, lived experiences, a method of this sort does not operate according to a set procedure; rather, it is an iterative process intended to generate cumulative and progressive insights.[4] While the goal of the process is to gain clarity about the world in general, as a *theological* method, its more specific aim is to develop clarity regarding who God is, who we are as humans in relation to God, and, by extension, how we might participate in the presence and movement of God in the world.

Here, students of psychology will once again find themselves at home within the domain of theology, for neither psychologists nor theologians pursue deeper and more penetrating insights into the human condition simply for the sake of self-edification (although it can be personally quite edifying). In a very real sense, the whole project is simply dead on arrival if it fails to move in the direction of

helping others. Much like optometrists making the most of a phoropter, theologians develop a method so that they might grow in wisdom themselves. But additionally, they seek to turn to others and ask, What if you looked at things through a different set of lenses? Which is clearer, lens number one or number two? Number three or number four?

Speaking less metaphorically and a bit more technically, what we are really talking about is developing a theological hermeneutic—a way of critically and appreciatively *seeing* and comprehending what might be called the "poetics" of life.[5] As a hermeneutic, it functions as a means for describing, interpreting, and understanding what humans make of the world (*poiēsis*) in which we live, move, and have our being. At the same time, it's an approach that allows room for (and sometimes demands) the reformulation of certain theological categories in light of our ever-changing contexts and in response to the data generated by fields of inquiry traditionally thought to be outside the domain of theology, such as psychology and the empirical sciences. In this respect, what we are describing in this chapter and will be demonstrating in subsequent chapters is not a static, linear procedure but a dynamic process for engaging in the practice of constructive theology that develops over time and in response to our on-the-ground experiences.

To be clear, we are proposing a constructive theological method because the focus of this book is on how students of psychology might go about doing theology as a lived practice.[6] It is therefore not an introduction to systematic theology, historical theology, or philosophical theology. We are not attempting to identify a single, coherent system of thought that can be traced throughout the various biblical, historical, and philosophical accounts. Neither is this necessarily a book on how to "integrate" theology and psychology, even if it might turn out to be helpful for those involved in integration efforts.[7] If anything, our approach to constructive theology precedes (and possibly supersedes) the integrative gesture by locating it within a larger interpretive framework. As biblical scholar and theologian Joel Green has suggested, given our account

of the doctrine of creation (which we will describe more fully in the next chapter),

> Theology is an all-encompassing enterprise, so that subsequent segregation of science from theology could not mean that science would fall outside the purview of theology. Moreover, in so far as science is present as one of the sources for the theological enterprise, theology remains open to the possibility of reformulation in relation to scientific discovery. . . . The question is not whether science will influence exegesis (or vice versa) since the two, science and religion, have interacted and continue to interact in a far more organic way than is typically acknowledged.[8]

As a consequence of this line of thinking, one of our operating assumptions is that students of psychology (and practitioners of psychology more broadly) need not become experts, for example, in the formulation of logical theorems or the historical development of theological doctrines. Rather, they first and foremost need a way of doing theology that allows them to put their theological know-how into practice. Because their primary task is to respond in life-giving ways to the infinitely complex, lived situations of other flesh-and-blood human beings, they are most in need of a dynamic, adaptable process that will provide them resources for elaborating on these concrete scenarios in ways that are necessarily creative and even improvisational, but no less clinically sound and theologically robust.

In certain respects, this is an imminently practical approach to theology. We are more concerned with developing a reliable set of strategies than we are with the tidiness of a particular syllogism or logical proof. This stands to reason because, much like therapy, constructive theology is anything but tidy. Both operate in realms that are inherently complex, which means that even if we could imagine the perfect set of doctrines that would make sense of each and every psychological construct, it would still be far from obvious which of these theological concepts apply in any given situation, much less how to apply them.

The challenge, then, is not how we might bring together two discrete intellectual disciplines, as if psychology (whether folk or

professional) and the psychological sciences weren't always already forming and informing our theology. Nor is it how to apply ready-made theological doctrines to a concrete psychological problem (or vice versa). Our key concern is how students of psychology might respond faithfully to the world they inhabit from their own sociocultural context—a "respond-ability" that requires both keen insight and discernment. And for that, we need something more than systematic formulations and models of integration, however helpful they may be. Put a bit more simply, we need a holistic way of doing theology (i.e., a method) that generates a lived wisdom.[9]

Scientific Method and Theological Method

One of the difficulties we immediately encounter when it comes to describing this kind of constructive theological method for students of psychology is that, by and large, the word "method" means something quite different in psychological literature than it does in theological writing. Part of this confusion stems from the historical development of psychology, which originally started as a kind of philosophy of human thought, emotion, and behavior but eventually shifted more into the realm of the social sciences.[10] Many of the subdisciplines within contemporary psychology (e.g., cognitive science, psychoanalysis, psychology of religion) continue to hover in an ambiguous space between philosophy, the social sciences, and the natural sciences. Nevertheless, over the course of the past hundred years, practitioners of psychology as a whole have made a concerted effort to adopt the research methods and empirical tools of the "hard" sciences. As a result, the term "method" is most often deployed among psychologists to mean the linear, predictive, replicable techniques used to construct and empirically test scientific hypotheses (think again of the methods section in a psychology article published in a peer-reviewed journal). From this standpoint, a hypothesis may very well offer a compelling explanation of a given psychological phenomenon, but its primary value is that it generates

accurate (i.e., mathematically significant) predictions about the observable world.

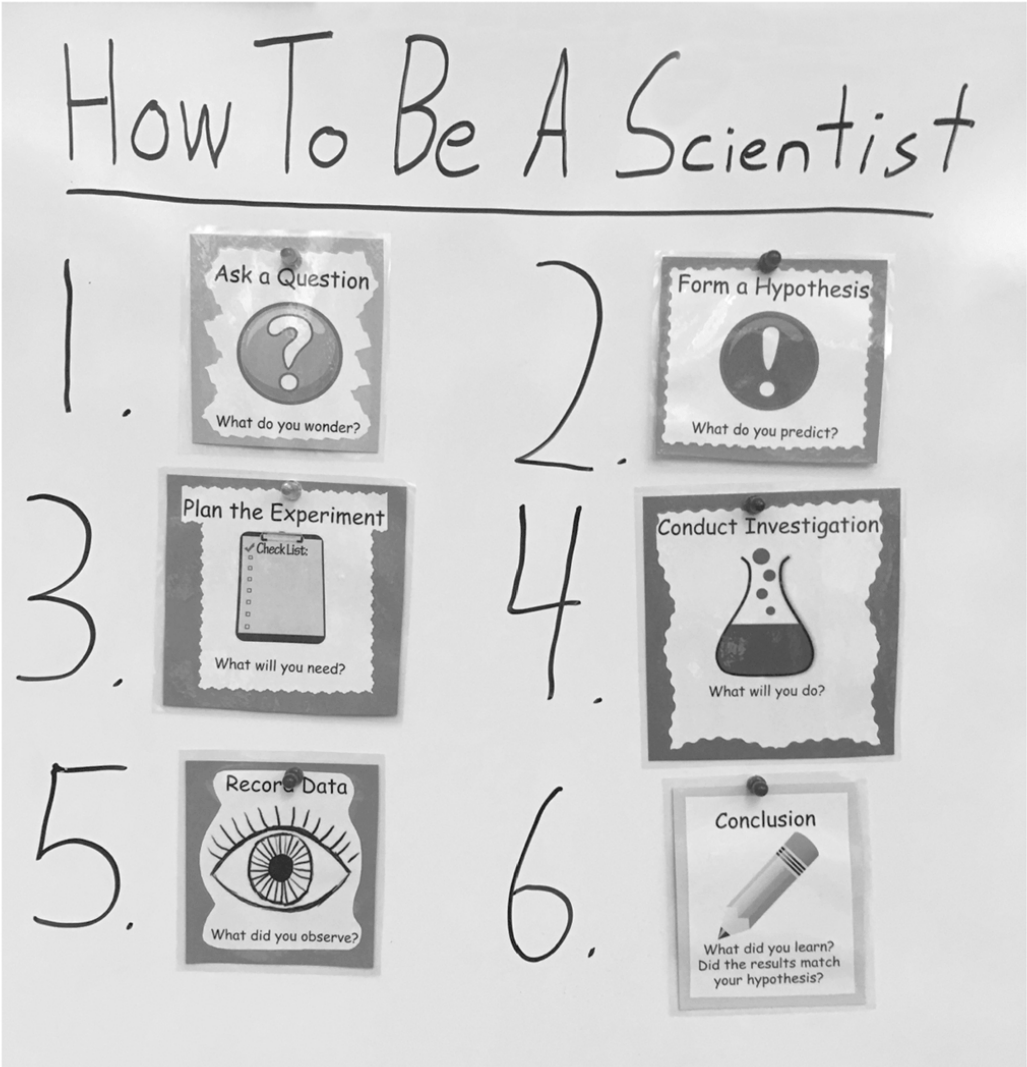

Figure 1.2. The scientific method [Photo by Kutter Callaway]

There are a number of ways to describe the scientific method, but for our purposes we can't do much better than the description we learned in kindergarten (see fig. 1.2). This basic, even elementary, understanding of "how to be a scientist" is not radically different from the way we might describe "how to be a theologian." Indeed, the process by which one engages in scientific inquiry shares similarities with the process by which one engages in constructive

theology. For instance, theological inquiries usually begin with an intractable question (about God, humans, and/or the world in which we live), and an initial prediction regarding how that question might be answered (i.e., a hypothesis). To explore this question, a plan is developed (experimental design), and a series of normative resources is consulted (conducting the investigation). Finally, observations are described, analyzed, and interpreted (recording data), and provisional conclusions are offered, which often include comments regarding limitations and possible directions for future research (conclusion).

These similarities notwithstanding, there are also important differences between the scientific method and what we mean by theological method. One key difference is that constructive theology locates the findings of scientific research within a larger theological framework. The insights generated by psychology are thus but one of a number of different data points from which the theologian draws. In truth, psychological scientists are only able to interpret and understand the data generated by their empirical research because they too operate within theoretical frameworks of some kind. Just as Thomas Kuhn suggested, all science takes place within a prevailing paradigm, which consists of a common (read: normative) set of theories, methods, goals, and even beliefs about the world.[11] The difference is that, whereas constructive theology makes the interpretive lenses guiding its explorations explicit, the natural sciences often elide (and sometimes altogether deny) their influence.

Put somewhat differently, both psychology and theology are inherently "traditioned" forms of inquiry, which simply means that anyone who operates within these traditions has inherited certain ways of understanding not only what they think their project is all about but also how to go about doing it.[12] Each of us is located somewhere (historically, socially, ethnically, culturally), and this basic situatedness shapes not only how we see the world but also how we are related to what we see (i.e., the objects that come into our field of vision). Indeed, anyone engaged in the practice of theology and

psychology would do well to come to a point where they are able to acknowledge that there is no such thing as an unfiltered, detached, or objective view "from nowhere."

As a consequence, identifying one's tradition and gaining clarity regarding its operative assumptions are critical parts of the constructive theological process. Whether a student of psychology or theology (or both), we always draw on other sources for making sense of empirical science, and perhaps more importantly, these sources function normatively and thus authoritatively, even if they go unnoticed. For example, clinical and research psychologists operate with implicit but often unacknowledged anthropologies (views of what it means to be human) and ontologies (views of what kind of "being" humans are) that inform, guide, and constrain their explorations of human thinking, feeling, and behavior. Even when they remain implicit, these perspectives regarding what it means to be human (and what a human is) determine not only which behaviors they find interesting but also how they gather and analyze their data and what they ultimately make of their research. By simply acknowledging these tradition-laden, embedded assumptions about human beings, we are able to critically examine them, explore how they are exerting pressure on our research projects, and revise, expand, or abandon them when necessary. In doing so, we also open our explorations to public scrutiny, which, in important respects, is actually a more as opposed to a less rigorous commitment to empirical methodologies.

A Process for Doing Constructive Theology

To describe theological method in this way is to identify at least two levels of discourse. Consider the phoropter again. On one level, it is helpful to step back and consider the device itself, inspecting the various lenses we are using, the overall sequence according to which we cycle through them, and even whether a given situation might call for an entirely different device. Second-order discourse of this kind is often called methodology, and it functions as a way of critically examining the apparatus itself—both the lenses through

which we see the world and how they interact with one another. However, when we refer to a particular method for doing constructive theology, we are talking about what takes place when we use this device in the real world. On this level, rather than looking *at* a particular set of lenses and talking *about* them, we are looking *through* them.[13] What this means for students of psychology is that to do constructive theology is, at its most basic, to engage in the practice of cycling through a series of mutually clarifying lenses in pursuit of a deeper understanding of human thought and behavior.

There is no single (or perfect) way of categorizing the various resources that are necessary for doing theology. Still, we can name at least five "lenses" that theologians in the (Protestant) Christian tradition have commonly peered through in order to gain clarity on their lives and the world: (1) the biblical text, (2) one's local worshiping community, (3) the historical theological tradition, (4) one's personal experience, and (5) the broader cultural context. It is important to keep in mind that this list is not organized according to any sort of hierarchy or preferred sequence. Each resource is critical in its own right, but there is no set procedure or starting point that dictates how we ought to cycle through these various lenses because, again, the key is to allow the insights from each domain to augment and clarify the others (see fig. 1.3).

Depending on the topic about which we are seeking clarity (e.g., social media), it might be best to start by reflecting on one's personal experience, one's cultural context, and how the discernment criteria of one's local church sheds light on the matter before moving to an (equally important) consideration of how the biblical text and the history of theological reflection inform, constrain, or otherwise guide these other perspectives.[14] It may even be helpful to experiment with some different sequences, considering the various insights that might emerge simply by choosing a new point of departure. Rather than determining beforehand where to begin or how the process will unfold, the key is to allow the unique focal point of each exploration (e.g., the spiritual

and psychological *effects* of social media) to suggest and, in certain respects, determine where to start and how to proceed.

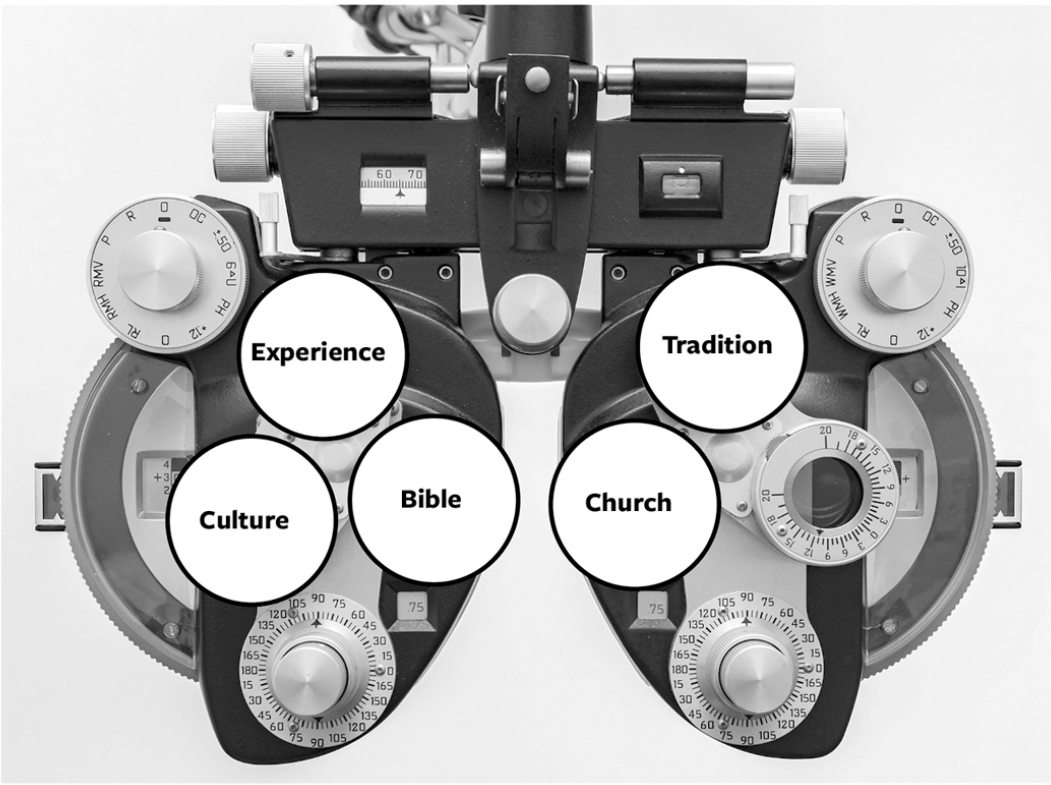

Figure 1.3. The five lenses of theology

Speaking of social media, it is also the case that, while it is important to cycle through each lens at some point in the process, they are not always equally helpful. Augustine and Thomas Aquinas knew nothing of digital technologies, so even though these two stalwarts of the historic theological tradition offer keen insights into the human condition, they may not be the first or even primary source one consults in order to make theological sense of the social media habits of contemporary individuals. In this case, it is likely that we would be better served to draw primarily on the resources provided by our broader cultural context (e.g., media psychology) and to place those insights into a mutually enriching conversation with our local worshiping community, which is comprised of numerous other people of faith who are also attempting to navigate

this media-saturated landscape with wisdom and discernment. To be clear, this is not to say that the Bible and the theological tradition are somehow unimportant or have nothing to say regarding contemporary phenomena like social media. It is rather to say that the ever-changing contexts we inhabit present a unique set of challenges that call for a mode of theological exploration that is equal parts nimble, creative, and adaptive.

For those who were hoping for more of a "plug-and-play" approach to theology, it might be more frustrating than fruitful to hear us repeatedly insist that all theological reflection is contextual and that every theological question comes with a unique set of demands. In the process of unpacking the various *mis*conceptions we all harbor about the nature and aims of theology, a certain amount of uneasiness is to be expected. But at a certain point, frustration can lead to disengagement, which would be the exact opposite of our desired outcome. So rather than continue responding to every question of "Where should we start?" with a cryptic "It depends," it's probably more helpful to point out that, based on our own experience, one of the most productive places to start is anywhere tension or dissonance can be found among the various theological resources.

At the risk of mixing our metaphors, Warren Brown has suggested something similar with his "resonance model." Brown, a neuropsychologist also engaged in constructive theological work, pictures the various sources of human knowledge as radios that broadcast signals with a particular frequency and wavelength, each of which has unique implications for our understanding of "truth."[15] The most reliable knowledge emerges at the point of convergence where the sound waves from various domains—namely science, rationality, experience, tradition, and Scripture—meet and overlap. For Brown, no single source or signal can be equated with the truth (not even Scripture). Nevertheless, our understanding of reality is enhanced and enriched when the signals in this acoustic field resonate with one another. Likewise, our understanding can become muddied when there is only dissonance.

Brown's is an aural rather than visual metaphor, but the implications are the same. In essence, to do theology is to seek a deeper understanding of truth by engaging in a dynamic, iterative process that brings together a multitude of epistemic sources. As such, a certain amount of dissonance is not only to be expected but is generative. Returning to our visually oriented metaphor, these points of tension are not hurdles to overcome but are rather opportunities for generating insight. Indeed, as philosopher and ethicist Caroline Simon has noted, "Orthodoxy is too often assumed to preclude multiplicity. If views are lenses, however, . . . multiplicity plus convergence yields clarity."[16] In other words, the goal of the theological task is not just about developing an ability to see the world (sight), it's about seeing the world well (insight). And to see the world well—to gain insight—we often need to look through a multitude of (sometimes contrasting) lenses at one and the same time.

Our hope in describing this kind of approach to constructive theological inquiry is that it will resonate with a wide swath of Protestant sensibilities. Nevertheless, it remains a profoundly traditioned approach to theology, which means that the process we are outlining here might not reflect the same commitments and assumptions as the tradition each of our readers has inherited.[17] Although we believe it reflects how lived theology most often takes place on the ground, some may be more comfortable with an established procedure—one that, for example, always begins with an analysis of the biblical material and seeks to interpret personal experience, the wisdom of the local church, the history of theological reflection, and the broader culture in and through this singular lens. Karl Barth is well known to have described his theological method in precisely this way: "Take your Bible and take your newspaper, and read both. But interpret newspapers from your Bible."[18] Using our terminology, Barth was suggesting that a key resource for doing theology is indeed one's broader cultural context (the newspaper). But for Barth, the Bible should always serve as the fixed "lens"

through which everything else ought to be interpreted and understood.

In certain respects, we are of the same mind as Barth concerning the role of Scripture in theology. As theologians, we consider the Bible authoritative for Christian life and practice—essential for the task of doing theology. There may be instances in which the biblical text has very little to say about a given topic, but at no point are we simply free to dismiss it or disregard it. That is to say, *what the Bible means* will always be open to interpretation and up for debate, but *that the Bible matters* is not in question. Borrowing again from Alasdair MacIntyre, the Christian theological tradition is constituted by nothing other than our shared commitment to argue about what this authoritative text means.[19]

That being said, we are also suggesting that, at times, it is appropriate (and even advisable) to "reverse the hermeneutical flow" and interpret the biblical text in light of the newspaper.[20] Some, following Barth, might worry that to move in this direction is to undermine biblical authority or to subject it to the fickle winds of sociocultural change. But these fears are largely unfounded for two reasons. First, while it is always important to avoid reading into the biblical text that which is simply not there (i.e., eisegesis), the truth of the matter is that we have no other choice but to read Scripture from our situated standpoint—from the concrete, sociocultural context in which we are embedded. Yet, rather than being a problem to solve, this is simply part of what it means for the biblical text to function as authoritative Scripture for the people of God. We read the biblical text not as isolated individuals in a hermetically sealed chamber but as members of a particular community, located in a specific time and place, responding to concrete issues. There simply is no such thing as a "plain" reading of the text. Pretending as if there were risks a host of self-serving distortions rooted in a lack of self-awareness.

Second, given that the Bible stands at the heart of the constructive theological task, it is important to underscore that, in its function as Scripture, no interpretation of the biblical text takes

place in the absence of the ongoing presence and activity of the Spirit of God. The same can be said of theological reflection more broadly. It is a fundamentally in-spirit-ed endeavor, which means that, whether we are interpreting the Bible from the newspaper or vice versa, the entire theological project hinges on the ongoing presence and activity of the Spirit of God who holds these various perspectives together in their creative tension. And just as we can be confident that the Spirit is at work in and through our reading of Scripture, so too can we be confident that, in conversation with our local worshiping community, the larger theological tradition, our personal experience, and the biblical text, the Spirit is also up to something in the broader culture.

A Cultural Lens

For the most part, the five lenses we have identified as normative resources for the theological task are fairly self-explanatory. As we endeavor not simply to know about God but to know God more deeply in our concrete lives, it is critical that we consider what the biblical text has to say (Bible), what our local worshiping community has discerned (church), how the historic theological tradition we have inherited navigated similar terrain (tradition), and the lived wisdom we have cultivated in our journey of discipleship (experience). For the sake of clarity, we have been talking about these resources as if they were distinct, but in truth they are always already interrelated, which means that a major element of the constructive theological process is simply being more critically aware of their constant interaction and, by extension, more intentional about how their various points of convergence and divergence might help us sharpen our vision.

Culture, the final lens, is likely the most fuzzy, both in terms of what it means and in terms of how it might serve as a theological resource. The primary reason is because, much like the word "method" (and "theology"!), the word "culture" often functions as an umbrella term that ends up being used in different ways by different people (even within the same discipline) depending on the context

and the audience. For instance, the great majority of psychology students are exposed to the term "culture" as if it were entirely about racial and ethnic diversity. However, cultural psychologists Hazel Rose Markus and Alana Connor define culture much more broadly as "the ideas, institutions, and interactions that tell a group of people how to think, feel, and act."[21] Their definition reflects their primary goal as psychologists, which is not so much to understand culture per se, but how culture generates our sense of self, that is, our enculturated identity. Employing a slightly different definition, evolutionary biologist Robert Boyd suggests that culture is "the storehouse of gradually accumulated, local, and typically tacit knowledge."[22] On Boyd's view, culture is more than a mere set of ideas that humans pass on to one another; it is the evolutionary principle that has enabled humans to spread, adapt, and thrive in nearly every ecological niche on the planet.[23]

A distinct but related definition can be found in the work of neuroscientist Antonio Damasio: "Humans have distinguished themselves from all other beings by creating a spectacular collection of objects, practices, and ideas, collectively known as cultures. The collection includes the arts, philosophical inquiry, moral systems and religious beliefs, justice, governance, economic institutions, and technology and science."[24] Notably, Damasio's notion of culture shares certain similarities to Boyd's, and Marcus and Connor's. However, beyond the transmission of shared knowledge, culture for Damasio also includes the creation of material objects and systems of belief. Depending on one's perspective, this more expansive view of culture either complicates matters to such a degree that the word means nothing because it covers everything that humans do, or it makes culture a rich and fertile ground calling for exploration.

These complexities notwithstanding, because our aim is to incorporate "culture" into a larger theological project, our definition is, like Damasio's, somewhat broad. From a theological perspective, we can say that culture is "what humans make of God's creation."[25] It might strike some as a fairly straightforward definition, but a

number of assumptions about the created order, human creativity, and divine agency are embedded within it. We will say more about these theological assumptions in the chapters to come, but for now it is enough to say that human culture-making assumes numerous forms. Each embodies a distinct set of features, yet shares a common thread, or "trace," with the others. Framed in this way, we can think of culture as something that is both tangible and intangible, both the concrete artifacts a society generates and the *volksgeist* (i.e., the spirit of the people) that animates these creative activities (we'll return to a discussion of how the Spirit of God relates to the spirit of people in chap. 3).

Whatever we call the common thread that ties together the various strands of a society's creative work, the primary point is that culture is embodied, expressed, and transmitted in and through a variety of forms that range from the concrete and particular to the abstract and general. Starting with the most concrete, we can think of human culture in terms of its material *products*—the various symbolic and technological artifacts it creates (e.g., tools, texts, works of art). But culture also finds expression in a constellation of *practices* (religious, aesthetic, political) that organize and orient our shared lives together, many of which incorporate (and give meaning to) the material artifacts we produce. These practices, in turn, serve as the lifeblood of numerous cultural *institutions*. The boundaries that distinguish institutions from the individuals that make up those institutions are often blurry, but generally speaking, institutions operate as both (1) a network of systems (technological, economic, legal) that organize our social landscape and determine how we ought to navigate our communal lives and (2) a series of underlying structures (political, ideological, mythological) that lend a sense of coherence to our collective activities, most often by providing us with robust narrative resources for envisioning our culturally specific social arrangements as completely "natural"—that is, as a reflection not of our particular location but of the way things truly are.

By mentioning these deep structures, we are naming a more abstract dimension of culture. But that doesn't mean it has no bearing on everyday life. Rather, at this level of abstraction, culture

begins to demonstrate a kind of non- or extra-human agency, exerting a top-down or whole-part influence that operates outside of human control and often without our consent. Indeed, it is only at this level of abstraction that we can speak reasonably about cultural *phenomena* (e.g., artistic trends, societal movements, political uprisings) and develop *theories* (whether philosophical, social-scientific, or critical) that explain these phenomena in terms of how they are causally associated with the construction of our *identities* (ethnic, linguistic, tribal, sexual).

Interestingly enough, the discipline of psychology is implicated in each of these cultural domains:

- *products* (research studies, journal articles, books)
- *practices* (clinical work, laboratory research, professional conference-going)
- *institutions* (universities, professional societies)
- *phenomena* (renewed nationalism, popularized cognitive behavioral techniques for weight loss)
- *theoretical frameworks* (psychodynamic, developmental, evolutionary)

Significantly, each of these aspects of psychology plays a part in the development of our sense of self and in our ability to come to a deeper understanding of our own intersecting *identities* as enculturated human beings.

As a result, the clinical methods, empirical tools, and theoretical frameworks of the psychological sciences are capable of providing Christians with much-needed insight into this thing we call "culture" (including the culture of psychology), especially as it concerns what it means to be a human inhabiting a particular culture, what it means for those humans to thrive in their own cultural context, and how we understand our role in helping other humans feel, think, and behave in ways that lead to their flourishing. Because it is a human project, psychology is far from perfect, but as one of numerous other lenses incorporated into the constructive theological task, it

helps clarify our vision, granting us a depth of understanding regarding the human condition that would otherwise remain inaccessible.

On the Other Side of the Phoropter

Some may be slightly uncomfortable with our apparent willingness to place the findings of the psychological sciences into a mutually enriching dialogue with the historic theological tradition or, perhaps even more distressingly, the biblical text. We will not be able to dispel these concerns in their entirety, but we do hope to show that it is for expressly theological reasons that we are able to identify psychology as a trustworthy (and even authoritative) source that can inform and guide our understanding of who God is and who we are as human beings. In fact, as the next chapter discusses in greater detail, it is creation's trinitarian structure that underwrites our ability to endorse what we discover about the world through psychology (or any science, for that matter). Likewise, in chapter 3 we consider how a robust pneumatology (i.e., our view of the Spirit) encourages us to approach culture with the expectation that we will encounter God already at work in people's lives. Finally, chapter 4 considers the incarnation as the key theological doctrine animating our approach to positive psychology and its vision of human flourishing.

Still, questions will inevitably remain. Which of the various lenses has the final word? When, where, and how does contemporary psychology function authoritatively, and what are its limits? How do we know whether our personal experience is blinding us to what Scripture says or granting us much-needed insight into an aspect of the biblical text that would otherwise go unseen and unnoticed? None of these questions are easily addressed, and in certain respects, that is exactly the point. At the risk of overstatement, constructive theology is rarely if ever concerned about questions that are straightforward or simple because life is almost never straightforward or simple. If it were, then wisdom and discernment would not be required. We would simply do what is obvious. In the real world, though, things are far more complex, which is why

theology takes practice and develops over time. It's not simply a way of thinking but is rather an ongoing process in which one returns time and again to a handful of intractable questions, asking them in new ways and in light of new contexts, refusing to soften their critical edge by pretending they could ever be easily resolved. Its chief aim is not the production of "knowledge" per se, but the development of our capacity to navigate the complexities of life in robust and faithful ways. And just like any other lived practice, the more we do it, the more it becomes a part of our body's habituated, unconscious, reflexive response to what we encounter in the various niches we inhabit.

Speaking of the body, the role of the larger community (i.e., the body of Christ) in developing these theological competencies cannot be overstated. The fundamentally communal nature of the theological task is especially salient for students of psychology because they are learning not only how to see themselves and their surroundings more clearly but also how to help others do the same. In other words, there is no sense in which their growing capacity for doing theology begins or ends with them alone. The same is true for every person of faith. But given their calling to enter a helping profession, students of psychology are preparing for a future in which they will be located on the other side of the metaphorical phoropter. One of their primary tasks in their role as psychological practitioners will be to help their clients see the world more clearly by having them look at themselves and the world around them from a variety of different perspectives and asking the question: Which is clearer? Number one or number two? Number three or number four?

The challenge, of course, is to do this while acknowledging that none of us have 20/20 vision ourselves. In some ways we are the blind leading the blind. Which is why, before responding, it is imperative that clinicians not only listen to their clients as they describe the way each lens sharpens or blurs their vision but also that they listen well. Just because the moon appears to us like a fuzzy glowing orb doesn't mean that it looks the same to everyone else. In other words, there is no such thing as a one-size-fits-all set of prescription lenses, in large part because no one's vision is

impaired in exactly the same way. And just as it is with physical sight, so it is with theological insight. Clarity of vision isn't about seeing what can already be seen, just with more depth and detail. Rather, it's about peering in and through the world that can be seen in order to come into the presence of what cannot be seen. After all, as Paul reminds us, "what is seen is temporary, but what is unseen is eternal" (2 Cor. 4:18 NIV).

Questions for Reflection and Discussion

1. How would you describe your current theological method—the process by which you make sense of your life and the world as a Christian?
2. What are the risks of the approach to constructive theology we have outlined?
3. What does "culture" mean to you theologically? Psychologically? Why does it matter how you answer these questions?
4. In what ways does psychology currently serve as a resource for you as you engage the world theologically?

Resources for Reading and Exploration

Neff, Megan Anna, and Mark R. McMinn. *Embodying Integration: A Fresh Look at Christianity in the Therapy Room.* Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2020.

Veeneman, Mary. *Introducing Theological Method: A Survey of Contemporary Theologians and Approaches*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2017.

Volf, Miroslav, and Matthew Croasmun. *For the Life of the World: Theology That Makes a Difference*. Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2019.

1. Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method* (New York: Continuum Books, 2004), xxi.

2. We are not the first to suggest that the phoropter might be a helpful metaphor for theological reflection. See Caroline J. Simon, *Bringing Sex into Focus: The Quest for Sexual Integrity* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012); and Robert K. Johnson, Craig Detweiler, and Kutter Callaway, *Deep Focus: Film and Theology in Dialogue* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2019).

3. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990), 1.

4. "A method is a normative pattern of recurrent and related operations yielding cumulative and progressive results. There is a method, then, where there are distinct operations, where each operation is related to the others, where the set of relations forms a pattern, where the pattern is described as the right way of doing the job, where operations in accord with the pattern may be repeated indefinitely, and where the fruits of such repetition are, not repetitious, but cumulative and progressive." Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 4.

5. In terms of framing the theological task in this way, we are indebted to William Dyrness, *Poetic Theology: God and the Poetics of Everyday Life* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2011).

6. We are thus sympathetic to Miroslav Volf and Matthew Croasmun's definition of Christian constructive theology as "to discern, articulate, and commend visions of flourishing life in light of God's self-revelation in Jesus Christ." *For the Life of the World: Theology That Makes a Difference* (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2019), 11.

7. An excellent example of how a constructive theological method precedes the integrative gesture can be found in Steven J. Sandage and Jeannine K. Brown, *Relational Integration of Psychology and Christian Theology: Theory, Research, and Practice* (New York: Routledge, 2018). Sandage and Brown advocate for a "relational" approach to the integration of theology and psychology, which not only takes place in particular contexts (and thus is not the only way to do integration) but also is inherently collaborative (i.e., it involves more than one scholar). Thus, for integration to be fully realized according to a relational model, both the theologian and the psychologist must come to the relationship not as incomplete halves but as whole human beings (and scholars) who form and (in)form one another in a dynamic of mutual reciprocity. Indeed, quoting Hal Foster, Sandage and Brown point out that "to be interdisciplinary you need to be disciplinary first" (*Relational Integration*, 90). In other words, "integration" assumes and, in an important respect, depends on the prior formation of the scholar/practitioner in a particular discipline, without which there would simply be nothing to integrate. Indeed, as we stated in the introduction, one of the principal contentions of this book

is that we are not putting forward radically novel ideas but that we are simply theologians who are asking questions about how theology might inform psychological research and practice.

8. Joel Green, *Body, Soul, and Human Life: The Nature of Humanity in the Bible* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2008), 24–25.

9. Indeed, it was in part her dissatisfaction with the available approaches to "integration" that prompted Megan Anna Neff to rethink both the purpose and value of using the language of "integration" as a practicing psychologist.

> Many of the traditional integration models and theories were built in the height of modernity, and therefore focused on abstracted theoretical models. As my classmates and I pondered what we were learning, one question kept swirling around in our conversations: "Yes, but what does this look like in the therapy room?" While we were learning important content, it didn't speak to the complexity we were witnessing or the "boots on the ground" questions we had about the practical nature of the clinical work we were learning to do. The class was successfully teaching us integration (theories and models), but it wasn't training us to *be integrators*. (Megan Anna Neff and Mark R. McMinn, *Embodying Integration: A Fresh Look at Christianity in the Therapy Room* [Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2020], 6–7, emphasis in original)

10. On this point, see Malcolm A. Jeeves and Thomas E. Ludwig, *Psychological Science and Christian Faith: Insights and Enrichments from Constructive Dialogue* (West Conshohocken, PA: Templeton Press, 2018). For those interested in how the historical development of psychology as a "science" has impacted contemporary integration efforts, see Kenneth I. Pargament's discussion in *Spiritually Integrated Psychotherapy: Understanding and Addressing the Sacred* (New York: Guilford Press, 2007).

11. Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962).

12. Brad Strawn, Ronald W. Wright, and Paul Jones, "Tradition-Based Integration: Illuminating the Stories and Practices That Shape Our Integrative Imagination," *Journal of Psychology and Christianity* 33, no. 4 (2014): 300–310.

13. For a helpful introduction to this way of thinking about Christian theology, see Joshua Strahan, *The Basics of Christian Belief: Bible, Theology, and Life's Big Questions* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2020).

14. William Whitney and Carissa Dwiwardani expand on these ideas using an "Integration Quadrilateral" in their forthcoming book, *The Integration of Psychology and Christianity: A Student's Guide* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic).

15. Warren S. Brown, "Resonance: A Model for Relating Science, Psychology, and Faith," in *Integrating Psychology and Theology: Research and Reflections*, ed. Al Dueck (Pasadena: Fuller Seminary Press), 293–313.

16. Simon, *Bringing Sex into Focus*, 29.

17. Astute readers will recognize that we are describing a slightly modified version of the Wesleyan Quadrilateral.

18. "Barth in Retirement," *Time*, May 31, 1963, http://content.time.com/time/subscriber/article/0,33009,896838,00.html.

19. Alastair MacIntyre, *Whose Justice? Which Rationality?* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1988).

20. We have appropriated the phrase "reverse the hermeneutical flow" from Craig Detweiler and Barry Taylor, *A Matrix of Meanings: Finding God in Popular Culture* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2003), 319n5.

21. Hazel Rose Markus and Alana Conner, *Clash! How to Thrive in a Multicultural World* (New York: Plume, 2014), xix.

22. This quote is taken from Stephen Macedo, who wrote the introduction to Boyd's book and concisely summarizes Boyd's definition of culture. Robert Boyd, *A Different Kind of Animal: How Culture Transformed Our Species* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018), 2.

23. Boyd, *Different Kind of Animal,* 21.

24. Antonio Damasio, *The Strange Order of Things: Life, Feeling, and the Making of Cultures* (New York: Pantheon, 2018), 1.

25. We are indebted here to William A. Dyrness, *The Earth Is God's: A Theology of American Culture* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1997), xv.

2

Creation as a Trinitarian Project

Key takeaways from this chapter:

- The doctrine of creation provides the framework for theological reflection on psychology.
- God has created a world that can be explored and investigated.
- The investigation and exploration of the created world by humans is one of the ways that psychology can be understood from a theological perspective.

Having its start in the 1940s, IKEA has grown from humble business beginnings, where it originally sold things like pens and wallets, into a superstore with locations all over the world. IKEA is primarily known for its affordable, flat-packed furniture and maze-like stores. You can go into IKEA needing to quickly grab a lamp, only to leave six hours later with a hot dog in hand for dinner, a dresser, and a date for Saturday night with someone you met in the bookshelf section while trying to pronounce "Hemnes." It is truly a special place. And, if you've ever wondered where those names for IKEA products come from, as I (William) have, they are named after geographic areas of Norway, Sweden, or Denmark. For instance, beds are often named for regions in Norway, sofa names bear a resemblance to towns in Sweden, rugs derive their nomenclature from areas in Denmark or Sweden, while other products are Scandinavian women's and men's names.[1]

My wife, Kim, is particularly talented at putting together IKEA furniture. She has a system that has never failed yet—a skill forged out of sheer necessity while a college student. Plus, she is exceptionally good at following directions, which I have struggled with since I was a child. First, she opens the box and finds the directions. Then she organizes all the pieces according to the different steps. Next, she opens all the plastic bags with the screws, nuts, bolts, pegs, and other items (I'm sure these other items have names, but I've never seen anything like them before). She lays out every single one of these pieces in its entirety first and organizes them by their numbers (if they have them). That way, even if the connection pieces look similar, she knows exactly which ones are which according to the numbers.

The next step she takes is to create the framework of the piece of furniture, which is the first step in the instructions. This, as she'll tell you, is one of the most important parts of the job. She'll also tell you to be patient and not skip to the end, because if you don't get the framework part of the assembly correct the other parts won't fit right. Once she is confident that the framework is put together properly, she goes ahead and moves forward by beginning slowly, step by step, to attach the other pieces.

As can be seen with IKEA furniture, frameworks are important because they provide the base that supports everything else. If you want to get that dresser or bookshelf to look right and to sit flush with the wall, then it's important to pay close attention to getting the framework correct before you move on. You can think of this chapter on creation as the framework that supports a lot of other theological doctrines for interdisciplinary work between theology and psychology. The details will become more clear in this chapter, but, in short, the triune God's ordering of the world and ongoing relationship with it is the framework that makes inquiry into the world through science and psychology possible.

As mentioned in our previous chapter, one of the key goals of this book is to help you as a psychology student to develop a greater awareness of and competency with Christian theology. We are most interested in helping you develop a greater depth of theological skill

and reflection regarding psychology and psychological subdisciplines. While the majority of our students come to us already interested in theological reflection on the discipline of psychology, the common question they often ask is, Where do I begin? This question is important because, just like IKEA furniture, our beginning theological reflections are a question about getting the framework right. In answer to that question, we suggest that the basic place to begin our theological reflection is within the framework of a trinitarian account of God's relations with the world.

God as Trinity (Father, Son, and Spirit) is not some sort of abstract principle or speculative theory but a serious reflection on God's mission in the world through the Son and Spirit to bring wholeness and healing to the created order. To make it more personal, when we begin with a trinitarian account of God's relations with the world, we are also engaging in serious consideration of what it means for us as the community of Christ to be a part of God's mission and vision.

God's self-disclosure through the Son and Spirit in the created world is the foundation, blueprint, or framework for how we can begin to understand the backdrop to our own embodied lives. The revealing of God's self as trinitarian is an important part of this framework for providing a vision for how our lives are transformed through the person and work of Christ. The mission and vision of God have an ultimate end or aim (Greek: *telos*), which is to sustain, redeem, and bring wholeness to humanity—and the entire creation. As will become clear, our understanding of at least some of the features that characterize this healing and wholeness can be guided by the discipline of psychology. So, while we begin with the doctrine of the Trinity, this chapter will argue that a trinitarian account of creation and revelation sets the stage for how truths about the world can be discovered through the discipline of psychology specifically and science generally, and how knowledge about the world is discovered through human interaction with the physical realm.

Understanding more about the doctrines of creation and revelation is directly related to the question of how we can learn anything at all from the human sciences. The doctrines of both creation and

revelation impact our theological reflection about psychology, and yet, they are doctrines that are often neglected by psychologists. That the doctrines of creation and revelation have been overlooked within psychology has not been intentional. It is simply that other doctrines, such as those pertaining to theological anthropology and the doctrine of sin, have oftentimes received more attention. The primary theological doctrine that continues to be the focus in psychology is the conception of the *imago Dei* (image of God),[2] and much of the time that the *imago Dei* is invoked, the discussion leans toward the negative aspects of humanity related to sin.[3] A focus on the *imago Dei* and sin makes sense considering that psychology specifically studies human thought and behavior, and often focuses on "abnormal" behavior or psychopathology.[4] However, out of all the Christian doctrines that are discussed in this book, the Christian doctrines of creation and revelation provide some of the most critical theological resources that enable us to have a more in-depth understanding of clinical work and research within the field of psychology.

Creation and Revelation

When we speak of creation and revelation, we are talking about two related but different Christian doctrines. For understanding the term "revelation," we are talking about how God reveals God's own self through the Son and Spirit. When we use the term "creation" within Christian theology, this concept is a bit trickier, since the majority of students understand creation to refer to the Genesis narrative and how God created the world in the beginning. While it is true that the doctrine of creation does describe the beginnings of human and nonhuman life in Genesis, for our purposes here, we must also think of the Christian doctrine of creation as being a unifying theme that operates throughout Scripture and describes God's initial and ongoing relationship with the world.[5] The doctrine of creation does form the framework for understanding God's triune action through the Son and Spirit in the created world since its inception. However,

in addition to this, the doctrine of creation is part of the larger Christian narrative that envisions the created world as the stage on which God acts to create new things through the redeeming and sanctifying work of Christ.[6] Consequently, when we talk about a trinitarian account of creation, we are saying something about how the triune God created in the beginning and continues to provide for both human and nonhuman life (like animals and plants) today. But in our understanding of the doctrine, it also says something about the ways that God reveals God's own identity within Christ and the Spirit.

By framing things in this way, several related theological topics rise to the surface that call for further exploration. A trinitarian account of creation does the following:

- Encompasses other doctrines like providence and common grace (terms we will return to later), both of which acknowledge that God continues to uphold, care for, and sustain the world
- Helps us understand how humans have a role in tending, keeping, and stewarding the earth through all kinds of activities, both aesthetic and scientific in nature
- Upholds the goodness of creation and the human creature, and maintains that the exploration of God's creation through the sciences or psychological science is a worthy endeavor
- Offers a corrective to the physicalism or naturalism found within some streams of psychology that reduces humanity to a series of behavioral or neurological processes
- Provides a vision for how creation one day will be made whole and encompass a new heaven and a new earth (Rev. 21:1)

In sum, the created world is the stage where we experience the triune God's continuous and loving action of sustaining the world that has been created, redeeming fallen humanity, and ultimately bringing about the restoration of the entire created realm.[7] The world that God has created is able to be known; it is a world that

can be explored and investigated, and this investigation and exploration are ways that psychology can be understood, at least from a theological perspective.

The rest of this chapter lays out how you might develop your theological skills pertaining to the doctrines of creation and revelation, and why these theological topics make a difference in your practice, study, and research for psychology. The aim is to help you more fully understand and explain (from a theological perspective) why psychology is a worthwhile endeavor by developing a greater awareness of and competency with a trinitarian understanding of creation. But perhaps even more important, our hope is that, as we discuss creation, you will begin to reflect on the lived wisdom of how God interacts with the world and human creatures and, in doing so, walk away changed—inspired by a vision for how God might want you to pursue your calling within the discipline of psychology.

Investigation into the Natural World and Human Nature

As authors who deeply believe in the benefit of engaging both psychology and Christian theology in conversation, we understand that there are some Christians who might not share our enthusiastic engagement with these two disciplines. Two possible reasons for these difficulties are that some Christians have either not reflected on how God might be present and active in the world at large or they hold religious and theological beliefs that make no room for God to be at work in the wider culture outside of the church. As a result, many Christians do not have an in-depth vision for how God's work in the world can incorporate discoveries in the sciences (even though these same Christians still go to the doctor and believe what their doctor says based on medical science). To counter such misconceptions, we find that a trinitarian understanding of creation provides the framework for how God allows elements of truth to be discovered in the world through the psychological sciences. However, we must acknowledge that some hesitations regarding psychology are well founded, and we should address them before moving on.

To begin, many areas of psychology operate with what we might call a *methodological naturalism*. Naturalism (at least in regard to the study of human thought and behavior) is the belief that what we can know about the human person can be explained through natural causes, and science can ultimately and fully explain the cognitive, emotional, and biological elements of human nature. Forms of naturalism also reduce the created realm of both human and nonhuman life to only biological, cognitive, and environmental causes and processes, and do not acknowledge any nonmaterial realities. *Physicalism* is a related term, and it describes a view of the human person as simply a sum of physical properties. *Scientism*, another associated concept, involves the belief that all things ultimately can be explained through science or scientific investigations of the natural world. According to scientism, if something cannot be explained scientifically, then it is simply because we don't have the scientific understanding yet to explain it. Scientism as a viewpoint will advocate that everything we observe in the world ultimately has a natural or biological root for the phenomena that we are observing that can be explained through science.[8]

All these viewpoints ultimately have consequences for how we understand both the world and the human person, which is why we need to understand how they are functioning. More specifically, these views have implications for understanding things like moral behavior and epistemology (how we know what we know) in addition to ontology (the nature of being). Methodological naturalism within psychological research simply means that in the normal scientific method used in psychology, the supernatural or spiritual are bracketed out in order to find causal or correlational mechanisms.

Naturalism and *physicalism* are probably viewpoints that you are already familiar with, even if the terminology might be new, since they operate in the background of many views that are expressed either explicitly or implicitly within the natural or human sciences. For instance, in his work *What I Believe*, the British philosopher

Bertrand Russell famously stated, "When I die I shall rot, and nothing of my ego will survive."[9] Sigmund Freud, in a similar way, operated with a naturalistic view of the human person that reduced conceptions of God to natural unconscious processes of the mind that were a way for humans to find safety in a father figure. Of course, this does not mean that Russell's and Freud's work can be characterized only in this way or that we cannot appreciate other aspects of their contributions to intellectual history. However, they do provide prominent examples of how both naturalist and/or physicalist understandings of the human person implicitly or explicitly operate in the background of many accounts of humanity from both psychology and philosophy.

Even if views of the human person are not explicitly stated as clearly as Russell's or Freud's, we must admit that psychology *does operate* with a functional or methodological naturalism. That is, psychologists are interested in understanding phenomena that fall within the realm of the natural and scientific, and thus bracket out any other kind of nonmaterial or supernatural causes.[10] This is perfectly normal and is the very nature of the scientific method that we discussed in chapter 1. However, even while operating within the bounds of the scientific method, psychology and other sciences are sometimes portrayed as providing a total and complete picture of human thought, behavior, and emotion—an understanding of the human that can be explained by psychology or science alone. Nevertheless, as Peter Hampson points out, even though this implicit (or sometimes explicit) methodological naturalism does occur within psychology, it does not follow that psychology can tell us everything we need or want to know about human nature. Said another way, psychology's methodological naturalism does not mean that, as Christians, we must subscribe to a comprehensive portrait of human nature that is solely naturalistic.[11]

Consequently, we must acknowledge that psychological research does at times seem to offer a portrait of human nature that operates with this kind of methodological naturalism. However, as Christians, because we believe that psychology alone cannot give a complete

and comprehensive picture for human existence (ontology), we should not reduce the human creature to biological, cognitive, or emotional processes, as the assumption of naturalism in psychological research sometimes implies. Although we do not deny the reality of these natural processes and, for the most part, uphold psychological research that explains and gives insight into these processes, as Christians we believe that these processes were created by God and are sustained by God's life-giving Spirit. Keep in mind that psychological science is limited to those things that can be measured and observed within the natural realm, and while it offers valuable insights, it cannot provide a complete ontology for the ultimate goal or telos of humanity in the same way the Christian theological tradition can. For the Christian who studies psychology, what Scripture says about the human person and God's interaction with humanity provides the fundamental ontology (or primary lens) through which we understand the nature and purpose of humanity.

Christian Scripture identifies a goal or purpose for humanity and, in doing so, provides an orientation toward human personhood for Christian psychologists—whether or not it is specified or explained through their psychological research or clinical practice. Psychologists who are also people of Christian faith thus seek to clarify what God intends for the human creature and to discern how the discipline of psychology might help illuminate these intentions. A trinitarian understanding of creation informs how one might understand the human person in ways that don't necessarily have to contradict psychological study but, in certain key instances, do remain outside the realm of psychological inquiry.

For instance, psychologists might give us many reasons why we should study human nature. Some of these reasons might include things like improving the quality of human life and ensuring proper development of infants, children, adolescents, and adults. Some psychologists might say they study human nature simply because human behavior is fascinating and worthy of investigation. All these reasons are well and good, and as Christians we agree to a certain degree. However, for the Christian who studies psychology, these reasons for exploring human thought and behavior are not the only

reasons why we should engage in psychological study. As Christians, we also believe a fundamental starting point for the study of the human person is the ultimate value and worth of humanity. Theologically speaking, the human creature is granted dignity and worth because humans are created by the triune God who loves and cares for creation and who redeems creation through Jesus Christ.

This would be an example of how we might understand our study within psychology to be *deepened* and *broadened* by our Christian beliefs and values.[12] God's trinitarian action through Christ and the Spirit in relation to the human creature is also an example of how the Christian faith offers a "lived wisdom" that we talked about in chapter 1. Our beliefs and values about humanity and God are not just intellectual processes but are also embodied in an ethic (concrete actions) that moves us to respect human life and to live out this love for God and others through our studies within psychology.

Some might still wonder whether it really does matter for our studies within psychology that we operate with an underlying Christian ontology that values the dignity and worth of humanity. In short, the answer is yes, it does. In fact, it matters ultimately. Whether you are pursuing a future in clinical or research psychology (or both), the dignity and worth of humans is rooted in a theology of creation. The value and worth of humanity outlined by a trinitarian account of creation also empowers us to be justice-oriented in how we speak up for the least of these (see Matt. 25:40–45) through our research and clinical practice within psychology.

Creation as a Framework for Understanding Psychological Science

Scripture gives us a clear vision of God ultimately moving and working in the world around us. In addition, it tells story after story of God inviting the community of Christ-followers (the church) to carry out God's work in the world. However, the biblical witness also indicates that humans are capable of knowing truths about the world

that aren't necessarily found in the canon of Scripture. As counterintuitive as that might sound, Christian theologians have thought long and hard about this topic, and their deliberations are quite helpful. Some of the ideas about how we can know truths about the world that God makes available are through general and special revelation, providence, and common grace.

General and Special Revelation

Theologians use the term "general revelation" to acknowledge that God discloses God's own self in the world, and at least some of this disclosure is evident in creation through nature. This general revelation of God does not necessarily provide or lead humanity to salvation, but it does mean that if God created the world, then we can expect to see God's handiwork displayed in the very things that God has created. There are some well-known Scriptures that illustrate this sort of evidence; for example, "The heavens declare the glory of God; the skies proclaim the work of his hands" (Ps. 19:1 NIV) and "For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities —his eternal power and divine nature—have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that people are without excuse" (Rom. 1:20 NIV).

These passages demonstrate that at least some aspects of God are seen in creation. Even in the beginning chapters of Genesis, God promises to be faithful to all creation and sustain it through the seasons and harvest (Gen. 8:21–23), thus establishing a general covenant of care for the world (this is the basis of the doctrine of providence). What we learn from general revelation is that God's relationship with the world continues unabated, and aspects of God's beauty, brilliance, wisdom, and order remain established for anyone to see in and through their observations of the created order. Some people might look at nature and see it only as a result of natural processes, but as Christians, we understand that there is a God behind those natural processes, and we often are moved with gratitude to God for the beautiful features of the natural world.

Special revelation similarly talks about God's self-disclosure and acknowledges that God is uniquely revealed in the person and work of Jesus Christ and in the continuing work of the Spirit. Special revelation also speaks to how the Spirit works through Scripture to help people understand the person and work of Jesus Christ. For those who grew up in some tradition of the Christian faith, special revelation is probably the more familiar of the two terms, especially insofar as it concerns the salvation and redemption made available through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

Theologians over time have talked about the "two books" of knowledge given by God. The first book is generally thought to be creation, whereas the second book is Scripture. In 1615 Galileo argued that these two books cannot contradict each other, for they both represent God's communication to us.[13] Oxford theologian and scientist Alister McGrath similarly insists that the doctrine of creation represents a unified understanding of knowledge and God's communication with us.[14] What this means is that the created realm and Scripture represent two related ways that one can know God, with Scripture embodying a more full and clear knowledge about God. For McGrath, there are not two different types of knowledge about God, one derived through general revelation and one through special revelation; rather, they are complementary modes of communication by the same divine reality. Thus, our approach, which is similar to McGrath's and those of numerous other theologians who have come before us, is to assume that if God made the world, then it makes sense that aspects of God's order, creativity, and life would be found in the created realm.[15]

One of the most basic foundations for engaging in theologically informed psychology is a unitary approach to knowledge that allows for certain truths to be gleaned from psychology. This does not mean that nature, the sciences in general, or psychology in particular give us specific or special knowledge of Jesus Christ that leads to redemption. However, it *does mean* that aspects of God's order, creativity, and wisdom are disclosed in the basic building blocks of the world. These indicators of who God is and how God

operates can be discovered by those who inquire. What is more, God's very self—God's presence—can be encountered in and through our exploration of the world God created. Indeed, it is possible to discover these things about God through psychological and clinical science because, ultimately, God made it so.

Simon Oliver notes: "Genesis asks about the meaning of creation. It begins with the same realization upon which the edifice of science is built: the idea that the cosmos is ordered and rational in such a way that we can make sense of it, not from some external objective standpoint but from within the cosmos itself. We will see that Genesis adds another crucial claim, which is more alien to our scientific culture: creation is rational precisely because it is good."[16] Because God has fashioned the world in a certain kind of way, with a certain kind of physical reality that is knowable, these realities can be discovered through rigorous scientific investigation (both the natural and behavioral sciences).

T. F. Torrance argues that nature may be "interpreted as pointing intelligibly beyond itself to God," but creation does not "permit any necessary inferences from its contingence to God."[17] This simply means that while aspects of creation (and the human person) are knowable through scientific investigation, the physical world can only speak about God in general terms and does not provide explicit knowledge of the life, death, and resurrection of Christ.[18] God did not have to make a world that would disclose something of its order to those who investigated it, but chose to graciously create a world that humans could interact with, and, in some way, come to understand through exploration. For Christians who study psychology, there are truths that can be discovered about the thoughts, feelings, and behaviors of human beings through clinical practice and psychological science. While these truths from psychology illuminate aspects of the wonder and complexity of human personhood, this knowledge does not provide a full-bodied understanding of the person and work of Christ. However, these truths should not be discounted or disregarded as lacking in value. In fact, it is just the opposite.

In summary, and from a theological perspective, God reveals aspects of who God is through the natural realm and Scripture. While these aspects of nature and Scripture are related, special revelation is clearer and more distinct than general revelation in the way that it speaks specifically to the work of Christ. However, general revelation concerns God's creation of, sustenance of, and ordering of the world. And while this order is complex, through exploration and careful observation we are able to learn about this world and the human person. The investigation of God's created realm can take many forms. We can explore it through travel, literature, art and music, and the sciences. Likewise, by drawing on the natural sciences or the social sciences, we can investigate the beautiful complexity of the world God has created.

Parents get a lot of joy watching their children explore and play on a playground or newly discovered beach. Children immerse themselves in their surroundings while examining every nook and cranny of their environment—finding features that adults will often miss. In the same way, we can assume that it brings God great delight to watch humans explore the vast playground of nature through the sciences and arts. Here is what Dallas Willard suggests: "God leads a very interesting life and is full of joy. . . . Undoubtedly he is the most joyous being in the universe. . . . We pay a lot of money to get a tank with a few tropical fish in it . . . but God has seas full of them which he constantly enjoys."[19]

Psychology is just one form that the delight-full exploration of God's world can take. The thoughts, behaviors, and feelings of humans are certainly complex. An argument could be made that, even when compared to what we know and do not know about the physical laws that govern the universe, human psychology is one of the most perplexing and uncharted terrains that scientists are attempting to understand. However, as Christians, we believe that, because God created the world with a certain order to it, investigation into human thoughts, feelings, and behaviors can and does yield results that will help us understand humanity. God created humans to be curious about creation (and one another). Through

cultural tools of investigation that humans have also discovered, we can explore the physical realm through disciplines like physics and biology and continue to learn about the human person through disciplines like psychology and sociology. God has made creation in such a way that it will "disclose" its secrets to the one who inquires, which means that creation may be investigated and explored through the sciences in general and psychology in particular.[20]

Returning to our opening metaphor, you'll recall that the instructions for putting together a piece of IKEA furniture usually begin with a picture of what the final product looks like. This picture of the final product is important, since it gives you an idea of what things should look like and the goal you are striving to reach. So, while the framework is the doctrine of creation, it is vital to remember that theological reflection with psychology and theology has a purpose or end goal. Moreover, as Christians studying psychology, our work has a greater purpose or end goal (*telos*) beyond just amassing information about human thought and behavior—or honing our research skills in order to get a job. The aim of becoming a practitioner of psychology is not simply to have a career or because we are enamored with the idea of seeing letters after our name (e.g., PhD, PsyD, MFT, MSW, LPC). Hopefully, as Christians, we are pursuing psychology as part of our vocational calling to align ourselves with God's mission in the world to bring justice, wholeness, and peace to those we come into contact with, through either our research or clinical practice.

As Megan Neff and Mark McMinn have pointed out, God by nature is missional and is at work "mending and tending" the universe.[21] Moreover, as the church, and as Christians who study psychology, we are invited to participate in the missional nature of the triune God through our vocation within psychology.[22] As a consequence, we can align ourselves with some of the missional activities of God through our work within one of the subdisciplines of psychology, especially given the fact that so much of the work we do within psychology is concerned with the well-being and flourishing of human life. One could even argue that, because psychology primarily concerns itself

with human thought and behavior, it has a special place within the sciences (from a theological perspective) as it examines the relational and personal dimensions of humanity, which, according to Scripture, is central in Christ's work of redemption.

Providence and Common Grace

The theological vision of the created realm we have sketched so far helps form the basis for how God works in and through the human activity of psychology. Indeed, if the created realm did not have a pattern or order, then the human enterprise of science or psychology could not take place at all. But what about those who aren't already people of Christian faith? How can truths about the natural world be discovered from scientists or psychologists who aren't necessarily Christians or even theists? Two other theological terms help us here: providence and common grace.

After creating the world, God promises to be faithful to it and sustain it through the seasons and harvest (Gen. 8:21–23). God's care for and active sustaining of the created order serves as the basic theological understanding of providence. Although there is evil present in the world, we are reminded in Job that if God withdrew God's Spirit, then all of humanity would perish (34:14–15). God's Spirit is the Spirit of Life—the One who moves within the created world to uphold and sustain that which God has created. The Spirit also works to move persons toward salvation, and as providential provider to the created realm, God as creator speaks a continual "yes" to life that sustains creation. As theologian David Fergusson aptly puts it, "The determination of God to overcome evil and not to abandon the project of creation is a persistent theme" in Scripture.[23] God's interaction with the world is continuous and ongoing, and the doctrine of providence helps us give an account of the diversity of actions that the Spirit takes to sustain the world.

The first way that we can understand providence is in God's work to restrain evil in the world. As Christians, we believe that, although evil exists, God keeps evil at bay so that it is not as bad as it could be. At the same time, as both Christians and psychologists, we

should reject notions dismissing or diminishing the reality of evil as something that is "not that bad." Evil is evil, even if those in power say that it is not. We can never dismiss the reality of pain in people's lives or invalidate the suffering that someone is currently experiencing. There is no way to easily explain here why evil does still exist, but the doctrine of providence provides an understanding that God does work to restrain evil to some degree.

A second aspect of providence that is important to point out is the way in which God allows goodness, truth, and beauty to still be present in the world, and for good things to come to all people—both for those who know God and for those who do not profess a faith in God. As Jesus reminds us, God causes the sun to rise on the evil and on the good and sends rain on both the righteous and the unrighteous (Matt. 5:45). In this verse from Matthew, we see that God's blessings still fall on those who might not acknowledge God or heed God's commands. God not only upholds the life of human and nonhuman creatures but also takes no pleasure in the death of even the wicked (Ezek. 18:23). God works toward the flourishing and well-being of creation, and although we might not recognize this activity, it speaks to the generosity and hospitality of God that is frequently present in our lives.

A third component of providence concerns how God works to allow truths about the world to be discovered by both Christians and non-Christians. This is a natural extension of the point above—namely, that God allows good things to be given to all human life—and some of this goodness is how God allows humanity to explore, discover, tend, and develop the created world that God has made. Theologians in the tradition of Abraham Kuyper have referred to these elements of God's truth being evident in the wider culture as common grace. Common grace is God's movement through the Son and Spirit to develop human culture and promote human flourishing even though sin is still present.[24] In short, God does not create a world and then step away and leave creation on its own. God graciously reaches out to creation, sustaining and perfecting the

created order, allowing humanity to discover elements of creation through art, science, culture, and, yes, psychology.

In addition to the idea of common grace found in the Reformed tradition and in the writings of theologians shaped by Kuyper, we also find helpful the Wesleyan notion of prevenient grace, which overlaps with common grace to some degree. Both "common grace" and "prevenient grace" are theological terms that describe how aspects of goodness, beauty, and truth are present in the world despite the reality of sin. There is a difference among the Reformed and Wesleyan traditions concerning how (or whether) this grace leads to salvation.[25] Within the Reformed tradition, common grace does not lead to salvation, whereas in the Wesleyan tradition, prevenient grace is the working in someone's life that occurs before conversion that does help lead someone to salvation. However, in the Wesleyan tradition, prevenient grace does not always lead to salvation since it can be ignored or resisted. Although they differ slightly, the important point to keep in mind here is that both theological traditions provide the necessary resources for understanding how truth can be discerned while sin is still present. Sin does disrupt the ordering of God's creation—within the human heart and in the structures and cultures of society—but it does not destroy God's good creation entirely, much less ultimately. God is committed to ensuring that sin does not have the final word regarding human and nonhuman creation, and the fullest manifestations of this commitment are the person and work of Jesus Christ and the perfecting actions of the Spirit.[26]

Kuyper's notion of discovery and development is particularly helpful for understanding the work of psychology. Certain dimensions of the created world can be *discovered* through the enterprise of science or psychology, and these discoveries can also be *developed* as a part of human culture. As Kuyper states, "The life of the world is to be honored in its independence, and . . . we must, in every domain, discover the treasures and develop the potencies hidden by God in nature and in human life."[27] For Kuyper, because humans stand in a certain relation with the world, they have the

ability to discover the treasures of creation and to develop these patterns found in creation.

Providence and common grace serve as two points of theological reflection that are critical for students of psychology and Christianity, in large part because they remind us that there are truths to be learned from the study of the human creature (*discovery*), and that, as humans make meaning of these truths, they *develop* a culture around these discoveries in the form of bodies of knowledge within psychological science. God has given humans a natural curiosity about the world around them (think about how Jean Piaget referred to children as "little scientists"), and in this curiosity we have a propensity for and are drawn toward social interaction with other humans. It also makes sense that some of this curiosity manifests itself in a basic curiosity about other humans and a desire to study these complex creatures through something like psychology (e.g., psychology is often one of the largest majors on university campuses in the United States).

Al Wolters's work *Creation Regained* offers a similar reappraisal of Kuyper but uses the terms "structure" and "direction."[28] Creation provides a *structure* (a form or certain degree of order) that enables the natural world to be studied, but it is up to the humans working in culture to give these discoveries a *direction*. For Wolters, the Christian is charged with directing their discoveries to the working of the kingdom, in whatever domain of study a person might find themselves.[29] From the perspective of a trinitarian account of creation, the Spirit is the one who makes things what they are intended to be. This can be seen in the realms of culture as humans have the potential to give further order to what is found in the created realm, and the sciences and the arts are examples of how humans further shape and give expression to what is encountered in the natural world. Understood from the perspective of providence, it is the Spirit who guides human effort in this creative and directive process. There is something good about the created world, and there is something equally good when humans use their talents and

creative capacities to learn about psychology by engaging with the world that God has created.

Giving Creation a Voice

Humans have a special role within the world of discovering and developing the created realm through the psychological sciences, and this is a natural and good use of the gifts that God has given us. Creation has an order that can be discerned, but because it speaks in terms that are often vague and ambiguous, it is left up to humans as agents or stewards of creation to articulate the wonders of the created order through their various endeavors. Whether plowing a farm, painting a work of art, performing research on human behavior, or exploring human nature and behavior through clinical work, humans are shaping the world. We are not the first to suggest that truth can be discovered through psychology, but there has been limited discussion regarding how psychology as a discovery-oriented enterprise contributes to God's mandate of not only developing or fashioning the earth but also giving creation a voice.[30]

This approach to creation suggests that truth may be discovered and human life informed and nourished from sources that are not explicitly theological, such as psychology. For example, psychology provides us with a means for articulating the various forms and structures of human thought, feelings, and behavior found in creation. In fact, it becomes increasingly difficult to understand how psychology might contribute to our knowledge and understanding of the world if we operate with a theology that does not affirm that part of our stewardship role is to develop the created realm through psychological discoveries. At its most basic, psychology is the exploration of the human person and behavior, but it can also be understood theologically as fulfilling our task as human creatures in exploring, developing, and shaping creation in a particular way. God has created humans with the ability to explore, wonder, dream about, and develop creation, and psychology provides us with a unique opportunity for doing so. Because God has ordered the world

in such a way that it is knowable to the one who investigates and explores, the created realm presents a reality that has an intrinsic logic. Thus, psychological scientists are right to assume that there are forms or patterns in the natural order that can be investigated and that psychological research not only helps discover truths about the created realm but also helps develop these truths.

All told, interactions with the material world are a necessary part of being human. Our physical world shapes and orients the cognitive, social, and emotional dimensions of personhood, which means that what happens to and within the created world ultimately has significance for the ways that we become persons.[31] Because the world is unified and ordered in a certain way, humans have been given the ability to investigate and explore the patterns found in creation and ultimately to give articulation to the order and patterns that are found regarding human thought and behavior. At the same time, human personhood is also shaped by the world that we inhabit through discoveries and development. What is more, these discoveries hold the potential for being developed and directed in certain ways, and for the Christian, these developments are offered up for the ultimate glory of God's kingdom. While not all theories in psychology entirely align with the Christian gospel, one can still conceive of psychology as part of the human exploration of the created order that God has established.

Questions for Reflection and Discussion

1. What have you discovered in your own psychological studies that has allowed you to know more about God's creation (human or nonhuman)?
2. What are some of the ways you might be able to direct creation in and through your studies and work as a psychologist?

3. What are the benefits of seeing the contributions of non-Christians in terms of common grace? What might the drawbacks be?
4. Much of the discussion has focused on general revelation and common grace. How might the Christian concept of special revelation expand or develop what we find in and through the psychological sciences?

Resources for Reading and Exploration

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Portions of this chapter have been adapted from William Whitney, "Beginnings: Why the Doctrine of Creation Matters for the Integration of Psychology and Christianity," *Journal of Psychology and Theology* 48, no. 1 (2020): 44–65, https://doi.org/10.1177/0091647119837024.

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28. Albert M. Wolters, *Creation Regained: Biblical Basics for a Reformational Worldview* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2005), 10.

29. Wolters, *Creation Regained*, 11–12.

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